KSG3613 INTRODUCTION TO ETHICS

The APA Ethics Code

Ethical Principles of Psychologists and Code of Conduct (2017)

The code has two tiers. Five General Principles describe the ideals to aim for. Ten groups of Ethical Standards set the rules every psychologist must follow, and can lead to sanctions if broken.

5 General Principles

Aspirational. The highest ideals of the profession. Not enforceable rules.

10 Ethical Standards

Enforceable. 89 specific rules of conduct, grouped into 10 sections.

General Principles

What we aim for

A — Beneficence and Nonmaleficence

Do good. Do no harm.

Protect the welfare of everyone you work with, and guard against personal, financial or political pressures that could lead to misuse of your influence.

B — Fidelity and Responsibility

Be trustworthy.

Build trust, keep to professional standards, accept responsibility for your work, and work with colleagues to serve clients well.

C — Integrity

Be honest and accurate.

Do not steal, cheat, deceive or misrepresent facts. Where deception is ever justified, weigh it carefully and repair any harm.

D — Justice

Be fair to all.

Everyone deserves equal access to the benefits of psychology. Watch for your own biases and the limits of your competence.

E — Respect for People's Rights and Dignity

Respect every person.

Honour privacy, confidentiality and self determination. Respect differences in culture, age, gender, religion, disability and more.

Ethical Standards

What we must do. Key standards in each section.

1 Resolving Ethical Issues

What to do when things go wrong.

- 1.02 If law and ethics conflict, try to resolve it; never use the law to justify violating human rights
- 1.04 Try to resolve a colleague's minor violation informally first
- 1.05 Report serious violations to the right body
- 1.07 Never make complaints just to harm someone

2 Competence

Work only within what you are trained to do.

- 2.01 Stay within the boundaries of your education, training and experience
- 2.02 In emergencies, help, then stop once proper care is available
- 2.03 Keep your competence up to date
- 2.06 Limit your work if personal problems could affect it

3 Human Relations

How to treat people and avoid harm.

- 3.01 No unfair discrimination or harassment
- 3.04 Avoid harm; never take part in torture or cruel treatment (2016 amendment)
- 3.05 Avoid multiple relationships that risk impairing judgement or exploiting
- 3.10 Obtain informed consent in language people understand

4 Privacy and Confidentiality

Protect what people tell you.

- 4.01 Protect confidential information
- 4.02 Discuss the limits of confidentiality at the start
- 4.03 Get permission before recording voices or images
- 4.05 Disclose without consent only when the law requires or allows it

5 Advertising and Public Statements

Be truthful in how you present yourself.

- 5.01 No false or deceptive claims about training, credentials or results
- 5.04 Base media comments on professional knowledge
- 5.05 No testimonials from current clients
- 5.06 No uninvited in person selling to vulnerable people

6 Record Keeping and Fees

Keep good records and be fair about money.

- 6.01 Document your work and keep records secure
- 6.03 Never withhold urgently needed records for unpaid fees
- 6.04 Agree on fees early; never misrepresent them
- 6.05 Barter only if not harmful or exploitative

7 Education and Training

Teach accurately and protect students.

- 7.03 Teach accurately and present information fairly
- 7.04 Do not require students to disclose personal history
- 7.06 Assess students fairly, on relevant criteria
- 7.07 No sexual relationships with students or supervisees you evaluate

8 Research and Publication

Do honest research and protect participants.

- 8.02 Obtain informed consent to research
- 8.07 Use deception only when justified, never for pain or severe distress
- 8.10 Never fabricate data
- 8.11 Never present others' work as your own (plagiarism)

9 Assessment

Use tests properly.

- 9.01 Base conclusions on sufficient evidence
- 9.02 Use tests validated for the people being tested
- 9.07 Do not let unqualified people give tests
- 9.10 Explain results to the person tested
- 9.11 Keep test materials secure

10 Therapy

Care for clients from start to finish.

- 10.01 Obtain informed consent to therapy
- 10.05 No sexual intimacy with current clients
- 10.08 None with former clients for at least 2 years, and rarely even then
- 10.10 End therapy when it no longer helps, with pre termination counselling

Numbers to remember

From the code

2 years

Minimum wait before any sexual intimacy with a former therapy client (10.08), and even then only in the most unusual circumstances.

5 + 10

Five aspirational principles, ten sections of enforceable standards.

2017

Current version, with the 2016 amendment to Standard 3.04 banning involvement in torture.

Source: American Psychological Association. (2017). *Ethical principles of psychologists and code of conduct* (2002, amended effective June 1, 2010, and January 1, 2017). This infographic summarises the code in plain language; refer to the full code for exact wording.

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